



WITH A BHUTTO DEAL IN PLACE AND CLOSE AIDE KIYANI AS VICE-CHIEF OF ARMY, MUSHARRAF IS ALL SET TO RETAIN POWER.

wards to break all index records.

Ever since March 9, when his troubles began with the attempted sacking of the Supreme Court Chief Justice Iftikhar Muhammad Chaudhry, he has never looked as confident in power as he does now. Only a month ago the threat of exiled premier Nawaz Sharif returning to a tumultuous welcome and the political momentum gathering against the General were giving his advisers sleepless nights. However, some deft manoeuvring on Musharraf's part and a surprising amount of luck have vastly changed the political scenario. First, Musharraf promised in the court that he would step down as the army chief before taking oath as a re-elected president, a vow that, at least superficially, acknowledged the public mood against him continuing as the head of the state in uniform. Lending credibility to this promise was the appointment of the former Inter-Services Intelligence head and close confidant, General Ashfaq Kiyani, as the vice-chief of army staff. Kiyani, widely respected for his professionalism, is

expected to take over as the army chief once Musharraf gives up his uniform. Another senior general and confidant, General Tariq Majeed, has been promoted as chairman, Joint Chiefs of Staff committee—the titular head of the three armed forces. These appointments—in place of retiring generals—indicate that Musharraf would like to have trusted figures as military heads before becoming a civilian president.

Second, and more importantly, Musharraf secured an understanding with former premier and current American favourite Benazir Bhutto, as her PPP refused to join other political parties in resigning from the assemblies. PPP's mere abstention during the presidential elections provided Musharraf the cover of a legitimate election that may not have been so clear had the entire Opposition quit in protest. He himself said in an interview, "Only 163 members or so out of an electoral college of 1,169 resigned, so where's the problem of legitimacy?"

KEY PARTNERS: PPP chief Bhutto (left), Vice-Chief of Army Kiyani

The resignation of the members of All Parties Democratic Movement (APDM) and abstention of PPP means that Musharraf did not face any challenge. He secured 57 per cent of the total electoral college votes and 98 per cent of the votes cast. The lawyers' candidate, former Justice Wajihuddin Ahmed, secured only 8 votes.

The Government was also able to drive a wedge between Jamaat-e-Islami (JI) and Jamiat-e-Ulema-e-Islam (JUI), the two major components of religious alliance Muttahida Majlis-e-Amal (MMA). Many believe the premature announcement by JUI leader Maulana Fazl ur-Rahman that his party's chief minister in the North-West Frontier Province would call for the provincial assembly's dissolution to break up Musharraf's electoral college, was calculated by the Maulana to provide the Federal Government the time to counter the move. As it transpired, the Federal Government's allies in the provincial parliament